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QUESTIONING HINDU CUSTOMS

Some of Thiruvananthapuram's old temples, especially the eleventh-century Sree Padmanabhaswamy Kshetram, recently revealed to be one of the richest temples in the world because of all the treasures deposited there by the triumphant Travancore maharajas of yore, are truly beautiful. This is where Vishnu is worshipped as Padmanabha, lying on the great serpent Ananta as he floats on the vast Ocean of Milk, the Kshir Sagar. It is in this posture that he is so revered that the kings of the Travancore kingdom called themselves 'Padmanabhadasa', servants of Padmanabha, and ruled in his name rather than in their own—a curious inversion of the concept of the divine right of kings, since here it was the kingly right of the divine.

If many temples are beautiful, though, not all old Hindu practices sanctified by these temples are. The ancient tradition of caste was one my nationalist parents tried to shield me from for years, and it was only at age eleven, when asked by a schoolmate in Mumbai what my caste was (in an incident I describe below), that I finally demanded an explanation. But caste as an instrument of discrimination was abhorrent to my liberal sensibilities from a very young age.

CASTE AND HINDUISM

It is difficult to pretend that Hinduism can be exempted from the problems of casteism, since the religion has been cited as legitimising this form of discrimination in some of its sacred texts. The *Rig Veda* does not mention caste in its original books and it first appears in the Purusha Sukta verse, a later interpolation that describes the sacrifice by the gods of Purusha, the cosmic man, to create all human life: according to this verse, from his mouth emerged the Brahmin, the priests and scholars; his arms were made into the Kshatriyas, the warriors and rulers; his two thighs were the general populace, the farmers, merchants and traders